to covertly support the Afghan resistance fighters or mujahideen [the plural of mujahid or 'one who does jihad'].[29]

America began providing covert support to the Afghan mujahideen in 1980, but this remained at relatively low levels through 1984 when a US Congressman named Charlie Wilson and a small coterie of officers from the Central Intelligence Agency [CIA] precipitated a shift in US policy. In 1985 President Reagan signed National Security Directive 66, which established the objective of forcing the Soviets from Afghanistan. US support jumped to $250 million per year for weapons and other material, and grew significantly thereafter.[30] With Pakistan acting as a staging ground for the Afghan mujahideen, Zia demanded complete control over the dispersal of all of this hardware.[31] The Afghan mujahideen were organized into seven competing political parties and the ISI coordinated distribution to them, a role that helped it to grow into the powerful intelligence organization it is today.[32] Support was channeled primarily to hard-line Islamist parties in the hope of undercutting Pashtun nationalism and ultimately creating an Afghan government friendly to Pakistan.[33] In addition, the ISI also relied on Pakistani religious parties, most notably the Jamaat-e-Islami [Islamic Party, or JI] and the Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam [Assembly of Islamic Clergy, or JUI], to recruit Pakistani militants to participate in the jihad.

The government of Saudi Arabia, which had agreed to match US contributions, contributed a vast amount of support as well.[34] The Saudi ulema also steered millions of dollars via various establishment-controlled charities to support the Afghan jihad. In the late 1980s the Saudi government and ulema diverged in terms of their funding preferences, with the latter favoring Jamil al-Rahman in Kunar province because of his doctrinaire Salafism and the strong emphasis he placed on social and ritual issues compared with other Afghan factions.[35] Al-Rahman had previously been the provincial commander for Hizb-e-Islami, one of the seven Afghan parties and a favorite of the ISI's. He split with the party in 1986 or 1987 and, with the help of Saudi aid, established the Jamiat al-Dawa al-Quran wal-Sunna [Association for the Preaching of the Quran and the Sunna or JuDQS]. It emerged as the most powerful jihadi organization in the Salafi-stronghold of Afghanistan's Kunar province.[36] In addition to sending funds, the religious establishment also steered a high proportion of the Saudis who